

One of Pandey's favourite pieces is a Ganesha that his wife made out of M-Seal—a multi-purpose sealant. It holds pride of place on his desk. Another is a set of 11 Ganeshas where each is a cricket player.

Pandey says Ganesha is also the God of creativity. "In my 40 years in advertising, I have not written anything by hand without first writing 'Om'—considered a symbol of Ganesha—on top of the page. Anything new you start, it starts with an invocation to Ganesha."

Over the years Pandey has bought several Ganesha idols for friends and family. "If someone has

"In my 40 years in advertising, I have not written anything by hand without first writing 'Om'—considered a symbol of Ganesha—on top of the page"

moved to a new house or is starting a new job, I have gifted them a Ganesha as a sign of new beginnings," says Pandey, adding that his mother used to do the same.

Ganesha also made an appearance when Pandey was the chairman of the jury at Cannes Lions International Advertising Festival in 2004, the first Asian to hold that distinction. "When I was the chairman of the jury in Cannes, I carried a small Ganesha idol for all the 41 members on my jury, saying that he is the lord of creativity, so vote from the heart and not by bias."

Pandey, who is considered one of the most influential men in Indian advertising and was also honoured with a Padma Shri, says, "Ganesha is a part of my every pursuit. But you don't mix advertising and religion." **BT**

@smitabw



MATCH POINT Srikanth Iyer, a Roger Federer fan, plays tennis for an hour daily

FOR THE LOVE OF SPORT

For Srikanth Iyer, Co-founder and CEO of HomeLane, sports is a great teacher

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

"I have always believed sports teaches you a lot more. It teaches you the importance of timing, the value of teamwork and also humility. Losing is fine. It teaches you perseverance. Don't give up till the last point. You never know when the match may turn around," says Srikanth Iyer, Co-founder and CEO of interior design firm HomeLane, who loves racquet sports and has been playing tennis for the past four years.

Iyer was introduced to sports at a young age when he started playing table tennis in school. He went on to play competitively and represented Bangalore University and Karnataka state. "But then life took over and sports was given a break for almost a decade," says the 51-year-old. When he returned to court, it was for squash. "I played that for 7-8 years till my body refused to co-operate," smiles Iyer who set up HomeLane eight years ago because he found a gap in the home improvement market. "The urban Indian middle class, when they

buy a new home, typically don't have any choice but to go to the unorganised market for anything that is fit out, such as wardrobes. We wanted to provide certainty in terms of quality, budget and timeline, besides great looking homes."

His latest love is tennis, which he plays daily for over an hour at the Chinnaswamy stadium in Bengaluru. "The nuances for different racket sports are very different. In table tennis, for example, spin matters the most. In squash, spin doesn't matter at all. In tennis, it's kind of mid-way. It's the nuances which make it difficult and also so interesting. I think I play a mix of all three sports when I play tennis right now," laughs Iyer, who is a fan of Roger Federer.

HomeLane is currently present in 21 cities and delivers 40 homes a day. In another 12 months, Iyer hopes to expand to 40 cities and provide 75-80 homes a day. **BT**

@smitabw

IYER WAS INTRODUCED TO SPORTS AT A YOUNG AGE WHEN HE STARTED PLAYING TABLE TENNIS IN SCHOOL